

CW0625018 6/17/05 8:21 AM Page 18

Guardian Weekend spooler 246x292mm trim size

Tel 0207 206 1000 www.feburman.com

E. Burman Limited
Communications & Design

and looked at me. "You're hurt too bad to live," he said to me, matter-of-factly. "There's nothing I can do for you."

I coughed a little and said: "Goodbye." Then I shut my eyes and fell back on the lawn.

In the silence following my death, as I lay still with my cheek against the scratchy warm grass, I heard Tim's grandmother call: "Why don't yall go play on the swings?"

"Because we don't want to," screamed Tim.

I raised up on my elbows obligingly. "Wait until she leaves," said Tim under his breath to me. He was angry, staring fixedly into the yard next door.

At last, Tim's grandmother called: "All right." The childish quiver of her voice as it trailed away made me feel bad. She went back inside the house, and I heard the door shut, with a forlorn, final sound.

I started to get up but Tim pushed me down on the grass again. "You're dead," he said. "You can't raise up on your elbow or talk to me or do anything like that. Anyway. So then." — Tim unslung a pretend rifle from his shoulder — "my dad screams: *You shot my buddy! I'm gonna get you!*" He ran across the grass to the bank of privet hedge that bordered the lawn: mouth twisted, fanning his imaginary rifle, spitting imaginary bullets: *eck eck eck eck eck*.

"Ha! Got you!" he cried. And then his face went empty; he reeled back, winced and jerked under a burst of automatic gunfire, then clutched his own chest and went down.

We lay there in silence for a few moments, staring blankly at the sky, before Tim got up and looked at me. "That's how my dad died," he said.

I sat up. Then I looked back at his grandmother's house — and saw a hand parting a curtain at a tiny upstairs window.

"Somebody's up there watching us," I said, and pointed. "See?"

"Oh, don't worry," said Tim, without looking, "that's just my mother," and as he spoke, I saw the curtain drop back down slowly over the window.

"Let's act it out again," said Tim.

From then on, I ran down the street to play with Tim almost every day — in his grandmother's yard but also in the tall weeds of an empty lot next door. If for some reason I was late slipping away to his house in the morning, he came down the street and pounded manfully on the back door for me. Then we ran away together down the bright sidewalk without speaking, crashing through backyards and hedges down to the jungle-flanked path where the assassin waited for us. All day long we dodged bullets in rank suburban tangles of elderberry and ailanthus and day-lilies run wild, scrambling on our hands and knees, running doubled over, darting in breathless zig-zags from point to point, cover to cover, running and freezing and running again, barraged by fire from an enemy we never saw. And again and again we staggered and fell before him — first me, then Tim; for though our battles became daily more elaborate and complicated (firefights; booby-traps; mortar-rocket attacks) the end of the game was always the same. Contorted in our separate agonies, we lay face-up in the buzzing heat, just long enough for our deaths to settle over us and soak in. And even after we rubbed our eyes, stretched and sat up again, we sometimes sat quietly for a little while without saying much, like people just waking from sleep.

"One more time," Tim would say — standing suddenly, breaking the spell. "But better this time."

I was used to playing with children like Tim — holiday visitors whose grandparents were friends with my grandparents — and when it was time for them to go home it was easy for me to say goodbye and run down the street without looking back. For a week every Christmas I played chess with timid Robby Millard, whose parents were missionaries in Mexico, and who had all kinds of stomach problems and took all kinds of medicine because he'd gotten an intestinal parasite from eating improperly washed fruit in Mexico City. And every Easter vacation I looked forward to Jackie and Sherilyn — twins, blonde and

freckled, older than me — who loved little kids and were constantly begging their parents for a baby brother or sister. The first time they'd met me, they had each taken me by a hand and led me up to the remote attic bedroom in their grandmother's house where they had set up housekeeping, kindly explaining that we were destitute orphans and I was their baby sister ("Hannah") who they were bringing up on their own. So every spring, for a few days, I was "Hannah," and Jackie and Sherilyn cooked and washed and swept and sewed for me and sang me to sleep in the "garret" where we all lived.

But Tim was different. We were the same size. His yellow-brown eyes were like the eyes of an intensely interested house-cat. There was nothing silly or frivolous about him and I felt that his seriousness made him my natural soulmate. I felt, too — intuitively — that somehow he wasn't quite as temporary as Jackie and Sherilyn and the others, and as it turned out, I was right.

Tim's father — the Lieutenant Robert Allan Cameron whose name was printed on the dog tags — had been Mrs Cameron's only son. But what had been announced by Mrs Cameron (at church) as a post-funeral visit from her grandson and daughter-in-law soon stretched beyond the usual two-week limit. A month passed; then two months. Painters were seen trooping into Mrs Cameron's house. Then a child's bed was ordered from the furniture store downtown. My mother — in an overly casual tone which did not conceal her curiosity — asked me if I knew when Tim and his mother were going back to Dallas (which was where they lived) or if I ever saw Tim's mother when I went over to Mrs Cameron's house.

"No," I said, and ran off. I was still little enough that I could deal with questions I didn't want to answer or didn't know how to answer by literally turning and running away.

Vietnam. The war was on the news every night but I couldn't understand it, even when my mother tried to explain it to me. The pictures flashed by in no particular order: bad roads, explosions, fires burning in jungle blackness; schoolgirls riding bicycles, and deserted-looking cities where paper blew down the street. An American prisoner of war bowed from the waist in all four directions like a maniac. The place-names (*Haiphong, Dak Tô, Ia Drang, Dong Ha*) were like something from a ghost story. Some of the far country places didn't even have names, only numbers, and some of the soldiers — mud-caked, grinning, staggering and falling, their helmets scrawled with ugly black writing — looked crazy.

There was something nightmarish about the dusty green gloss of the camellia bushes, deep deep cover where our sniper lay and waited for us. Every day, he drew us in as if by a poisonous charm; every day we dove from the trap and crawled for cover, as round after round of fire cracked over our heads. The skirmish took on very different moods, depending on the time of day: damp, overcast mornings, with dew and frantic birdsong; shadowless noons where the sun beat down empty and white; violent afternoon downpours that swept in on us in moments, no warning but a sudden blackening of the sky, and then a gust that sent the leaves flying. Together we hid under the trees as Tim's grandmother called us uselessly from the back porch, the strong wind snatching the words from her mouth. But the rains blew over us and pattered away almost as quickly as they came — sometimes in less than a minute — and then the sun poured out with almost unimaginable brilliance on the rainwashed greenery. With dripping hair, clothes plastered to our bodies, we dropped to our knees and crawled from beneath our tree and commenced our battle again. It was only a matter of time before I was struck, then Tim, before we clutched the grass and died on the ground together in blood-smeared agony — but still we fought every day until the fireflies came out, until it was almost too dark to see. And even when I was supposed to be dead, sometimes I opened my eyes to sneak a look over at Tim because he was so locked-in, face turned up and staring raptly over the twilight garden and out into some different reality; and though I was never sure exactly what he saw (white smoke? incoming helicopters? tracer

18 June 25 2005 | The Guardian Weekend

